

Zeke Zalinski

Director of UX / Experience Strategy & Design Systems

Summary

Design executive with 25+ years spanning fine art, agency creative direction, e-commerce, and brand. For the last decade, building and restructuring UX departments inside VC-backed SaaS environments, including the unification of fragmented product experiences across built and acquired portfolios. Recruited directly by C-suite leadership at both of my last two roles to establish process and standards from the ground up and deliver unified experiences across multi-product portfolios. Equally fluent in craft and strategy, with the range to operate at both the pixel and the executive level.

Capabilities

- UX org buildout, team mentorship & talent development
- Cross-functional leadership and C-suite partnership: thought leadership, product, customer success, design, back-end, front-end dev, and executive design strategy
- Design systems architecture: scalable guardrails for engineering autonomy
- AI-assisted design workflow integration (Figma Make, Lovable, Claude)
- UX Direction: wireframes, prototypes & specs, plus continuous discovery and research integration
- Post-acquisition UX portfolio alignment

Work Experience

VelocityEHS / Director of User Experience & Design / June 2021 – May 2026

Promoted to Director in September 2022 after 15 months leading the integration of a newly acquired company's software onto the VelocityEHS design system. Recruited directly by the CTO, a relationship built over five years at Maestro Health, to assess and restructure a UX department supporting a mixed portfolio of 20+ organically built and acquired EHS and ESG SaaS products.

- Grew the Accelerate Design System from one product's component library into the standard across 20+ products, scaling it with Front End across 6 Scrum teams.
- Designed the process behind a company-wide initiative to migrate every standalone application onto Accelerate, reaching 95% customer adoption by year end, reported directly by the company president.
- Caught a gap between the navigation experience leadership was promising and what the product actually delivered, then led the fix: Accelerate Navigation, now the company-wide standard.
- Designed the brand and interaction model for Vêlo, an embedded AI assistant, and brought AI tools like Figma Make and Lovable into the department's own workflow, cutting the time from idea to stakeholder buy-in.
- Built an in-house WCAG/VPAT accessibility practice, led by a Senior Designer instead of an outside vendor, to meet enterprise and education-sector requirements.
- Mentored the team through harder systems problems, then trimmed it from 8 to 5, keeping the people ready to grow into more.

Career Pause / Full-time Parent / February 2020 – June 2021

Stepped back from professional work to manage family full-time during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Maestro Health / Director of Experience Design / February 2015 – February 2020

Recruited by referral from a former colleague to join a 30-person healthcare startup as its first and only UX voice. Tasked with ownership of the full experience, from discovery through delivery.

- Served as the sole UX leader across 12 healthcare applications for three years, owning the full experience in a regulated, data-heavy environment.
- Designed custom applications from the ground up that replaced paper-based HR workflows, solving problems no one had digitized before.
- Built the department's UX process from scratch, scaling it as the company grew from a 30-person startup to a full insurance platform.
- Made a deliberate first hire in year three: a research and documentation specialist, brought on exactly when the product's complexity demanded it.

Z Design (Independent) / UX & Interaction Design Consultant / September 2013 - March 2015

- Led UX and design at Rocket Web, translating business and project goals into e-commerce content, design, and UX strategy, while helping shape how the agency branded its own offerings to the market.
- Partnered with 50,000feet's UX Director and Director of Development on several Abbott Labs engagements, and provided project direction and consultation as the agency planned and built its own new website.

Siteworx / Creative Director, Chicago / September 2012 – September 2013

One of four founding directors of Siteworx's first remote office, the only location to launch with leadership across all four pillars: sales, development, engagement, and design.

- Led the creative department through the full client lifecycle: discovery and stakeholder interviews, concept, production, and development handoff.
- Concepted and presented directly for clients like Grant Thornton and American College of Surgeons, with the ACS design direction selected and winning the contract.
- Operated as a full business partner alongside sales, development, and engagement leads: pitches, SOW approvals, resource planning, and account strategy.

Earlier Career / Art Direction, Design & Creative Leadership

- **Lyons Consulting Group**, Associate Creative Director: led e-commerce design work on Magento and Demandware CMS platforms, and led the agency's own rebrand as primary client-facing creative lead.
- **Gorilla**, Senior Design Lead: e-commerce and IA lead during the agency's Magento Partner of the Year win; IMCA Award for Axient.net.
- **Envisionit Media**, Art Director: led ground-up art direction and client design, ran the agency's print production routing process, then moved into the agency's first web work, designing email campaigns and marketing ads as digital emerged.
- **Italia Partners & Z Design** (contract), Designer / Senior Designer: national campaign work for CompUSA, Chicago Tribune, Foote Cone & Belding, and Euro RSCG Tatham.

Education

Illinois State University

Bachelor of Fine Arts, Graphic Design